

Chapter 106-1 - Return

When Jiuying found Ning Fuyi, the snow had already stopped. Mountains were covered in snow, all birds had vanished¹, and the world was a vast expanse of white.

Ning Fuyi was covered in a thick layer of white snow. From afar, she looked like an ice sculpture - if one didn't come close, it was impossible to tell she was a living person.

Su Mo in her arms was covered entirely by the cloak, but her face was pale as snow, already without breath.

Jiuying stood before her for a long time, reaching out to melt the frost on Ning Fuyi's face.

After a long while, Ning Fuyi finally moved. She silently lifted Su Mo, snow falling from her body with rustling sounds. Her steps were somewhat unsteady at first, but quickly became steady.

Jiuying wanted to say something, but seeing her empty gaze, couldn't speak. She only picked up the jade hairpin that had fallen to the ground and followed silently.

The charcoal fire burned in the morning was still not extinguished inside the house. The warm temperature melted the snow on their bodies. Ning Fuyi set Su Mo down, her hand stroking her face - ice cold.

"We knew this day would come. This was just one lifetime of the Divine Venerable. Su Mo had to die for the Divine Venerable to return." Jiuying spoke.

"I know." Ning Fuyi said. Her hand left Su Mo's face, slowly moving to rest on her own heart, frowning. "But..."

"It still hurts so much."

Tears fell pattering down, scalding hot.

Having witnessed these days, Jiuying couldn't say anything now. She could only stand aside and hand her a handkerchief.

"I want to accompany her for one more night. We'll talk tomorrow." Ning Fuyi's voice was muffled.

"Alright." Jiuying said. "I'll be outside."

The door opened and closed. Ning Fuyi carefully lay down on the bed fully clothed, lying side by side with Su Mo who seemed to be sleeping, leaning her face close to hers.

Beside the pillow was a wooden box. Ning Fuyi reached out to open it - inside were neatly arranged pills, placed there by Su Mo at some unknown time.

She took one and put it in her mouth. The clear, bitter taste immediately surged from her tongue to her throat, making her cry from the bitterness.

The next day was even colder. Snow had begun falling again last night, stopping only at midnight. The accumulated snow broke many tree branches - a noisy night.

Ning Fuyi found the grave of Su Mo's parents. It wasn't a randomly buried mound of earth, but a proper tomb built with brick and stone, with an upright stone tablet. The area around the grave had been kept clean by Su Mo, with no wild grass growing.

But now it too was covered with snow, desolate and forlorn.

Following Su Mo's words, Ning Fuyi dressed her in white clothes, placed her in a coffin, then carried the coffin for burial, erecting a tablet carved with: "My beloved, Su Mo."

Jiang Li and the others all came to see her off. Though none followed mortal burial rites, they still wore hemp mourning clothes and stood silently in the distance, watching Ning Fuyi's figure as she bowed her head to burn paper money.

Rolling thick smoke rose from the fire basin. Ning Fuyi's tall figure was hunched, no longer looking so graceful.

Even Jiuying had changed out of her usual red clothes, wearing white as she stood in the snow, sighing: "How tragic it is when one's beloved dies before their eyes."

"Yet she has witnessed it twice." Jiang Li spoke, gripping her sleeves.

The two bowed their heads together, momentarily silent.

Just then, a small dot appeared in the vast whiteness. As it grew closer, they could see it was a parrot, its bright feathers even more vivid against the snow.

The bird flew while calling, its voice mournful and unpleasant. Seeing this, Jiuying felt a chill throughout her body and quickly waved her hand to intercept it. However, the bird dove down to avoid the red light she sent out.

It crashed head-first into the tombstone. Its calls stopped abruptly, and the surroundings immediately fell silent.

This commotion startled Ning Fuyi. Jiuying covered her red lips, about to rush forward, but was pulled back by Jiang Li.

"This bird has lived so long - it's already had a long life. It wishes to follow its master in death. You needn't be sad." She patted Jiuying's back. "Let's go. Let her be alone for a while."

"Medical Immortal Jiang, you shouldn't blame Lord Qilin². After all, during the year our master was with Su Mo, this bird was entirely cared for by her. Naturally they developed feelings." Hannya spoke up to explain.

Jiuying shook her head, her hand falling unconsciously, closing her eyes: "Forget it. Let's go."

The group left one after another, so in the deadly silent whiteness, only Ning Fuyi remained.

She stared in shock at the dead parrot, stunned with grief for a long while, then silently placed a paper offering in the fire basin. The fire made her face feel burning hot while her back felt cold.

The sound of footsteps crunching into snow came from the distance - heavy steps that should belong to a mortal. Ning Fuyi didn't move. When the person stopped before the grave, she finally spoke.

"Who goes there?" Her voice was low and hoarse.

"You must be Liu Dieyi³. Su Mo often mentioned you." The person spoke with a clear, gentle voice, placing a flower before Su Mo's grave.

"Qi Yunlou?" Ning Fuyi hummed in acknowledgment. "She mentioned you too."

"I never imagined our first meeting would be at her passing. Life is truly strange." Qi Yunlou's tone was sighing, with little sorrow.

She crouched down, reaching out to warm her hands by the fire basin. Her ink-stained, distinct knuckles made Ning Fuyi feel somewhat dazed.

So she turned to look, and the hand holding paper money nearly fell into the fire basin. The woman quickly grabbed her wrist and gently moved it away.

She comforted: "Each person has their fate. Those who are gone are gone, but the living must still live."

Ning Fuyi stared fixedly at her face. At first she thought she was seeing things, but after closing her eyes, it was still the same face - clear and gentle, always seeming to smile.

Her already dried tears began flowing again, more unrestrained than yesterday. She almost hugged her knees and wailed loudly, as if she had suffered some great injustice.

Only then did the woman become somewhat flustered. She reached out hesitantly for a long while before pulling her shoulder to pat it.

"This girl, how is it that comforting you makes you cry even more?" The woman shook her head, naturally pinching her sleeve to wipe her tears. But after wiping twice, she suddenly realized what she was doing and stopped her hand in mid-air.

She stared for a long time before putting her hand down, looking at Ning Fuyi in bewilderment.

"It's nearly New Year, so it is rather cold." The woman looked up, her voice steady. "But once New Year passes, it will be another warm spring."

Her voice was like warm spring sunshine, soothing the restlessness in one's heart. Ning Fuyi's crying gradually subsided.

"I don't think I've ever met you before." The woman was also somewhat puzzled, chuckling lightly. "Perhaps I've been too deep in thought lately, seeing familiarity in everyone."

"We haven't met." Ning Fuyi said with a post-crying nasal tone. She lifted her neck to breathe in the crisp air and smiled slightly.

"I thought so - just my poor eyesight." The woman also smiled. She patted a flat stone behind her, bent down to sit, and took out a wine pot from her traveling bag, handing it to Ning Fuyi.

"Drink some to warm yourself. It's home-brewed, not strong." She said.

Ning Fuyi uncorked it and took a gulp. The spicy wine flowed down her throat. She closed her eyes and laughed through her red eye rims.

"Got you." The woman raised her eyebrows at her, then took the wine pot to pour into her own mouth. "In this situation and scene, I quite want to compose a poem..."

"Don't compose any. I hate those sour poems most." Ning Fuyi said as she grabbed the wine pot back and took several more gulps, trembling from the heat.

"Tsk, no appreciation." The woman didn't mind at all, lightly patting her back.

Ning Fuyi looked at the woman's face and spoke: "Carrying a traveling bag, where are you going?"

"Qi Kingdom⁴. This damn place - this old lady doesn't want to stay anymore." The woman weighed the wine pot. "The carriage is stopped at the foot of the mountain. I'll leave after seeing Su Mo off."

"Qi Kingdom - a good place, suitable for you." Ning Fuyi nodded.

She was silent for a moment, then said: "May I ask a question?"

"Speak."

"If you were to have offspring in the future, and she turned out to be no good person - ordinary and common, without talent or ability - and you suffered great hardships because of her."

"Would you regret giving birth to her?"

The woman's almond eyes swept over Ning Fuyi, seeming to understand as she rubbed her frost-reddened hands: "You're talking about yourself, aren't you?"

Ning Fuyi was surprised by her perceptiveness and tacitly agreed.

"A dissolute person like me having a daughter?" The woman laughed, then thought seriously. "Ten years for a chance encounter, a hundred years to share a boat⁵. If we could become mother and daughter, that would be fate cultivated over several lifetimes."

"What does it matter if she's ordinary? What do disasters matter? The world is mostly filled with ordinary people. Disasters are given by heaven and earth, and heaven and earth are all living beings. To blame it on one person is too unreasonable."

"Besides, I believe in my child. No matter how bitter or difficult it gets, she could be like grass in the wind - though it may wither, it grows again every year."

Ning Fuyi bit her lips and smiled, turning her head toward the white snow to hide the moisture in her eyes.

"Don't be moved. I said the same thing to Su Mo." The woman rose freely, breathing into her hands. "It's getting late. I must go."

She turned and stepped into the snow, but was pulled back by her cloak by Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi opened her mouth, then said: "You're very much like an old friend of mine. May I... hug you?"

"Meeting you for the first time, yet you feel like an old friend returning. Good imagery." The woman smiled, suddenly reaching out to Ning Fuyi. The two stepped forward and embraced tightly.

Ning Fuyi closed her eyes lovingly. A place in her heart that had always been vacant filled itself and returned to wholeness.

"Alright, farewell." The woman released her without further delay, turned and left. Her steps were unsteady, but soon she disappeared into the wind and snow.

Snow began falling again. Ning Fuyi looked up with a smile.

Farewell, Mother.

Farewell, Ning Changfeng⁶.

When she turned back to face the tombstone, the fragility in her eyes was gone, replaced by calm determination. Her left hand summoned a soul-chasing candle⁷, her right hand took out the gardenia flower that was shivering from cold.

The flower seemed to know everything and no longer threw tantrums with her, but silently nuzzled against her fingertips.

Footnotes:

1. **"Mountains covered in snow, all birds had vanished"** (千山覆雪，万鸟飞绝) - This echoes a famous line from classical Chinese poetry about winter desolation.
2. **Lord Qilin (麒麟大人)** - Referring to Jiuying in her divine beast form, as qilin (unicorn/kyrin) are legendary creatures.
3. **Liu Dieyi (柳蝶衣)** - The false name Ning Fuyi used when living as a mortal with Su Mo.
4. **Qi Kingdom (岐国)** - The progressive kingdom mentioned earlier where women can take imperial examinations.
5. **"Ten years for a chance encounter, a hundred years to share a boat"** (十年换一擦肩，百年换得同船) - A Buddhist saying about the rarity and preciousness of human connections.
6. **Ning Changfeng (宁长风)** - Ning Fuyi's adoptive mother/mentor from her previous life, whose reincarnation appears as Qi Yunlou.
7. **Soul-chasing candle (追魂烛)** - A magical item used in supernatural rituals, likely to help with Su Mo's soul transition.